



Course correction: Aryna Sabalenka is expected to win the Australian Open and avenge her loss to Madison Keys in last year's final.

and unprecedented drought will continue. No. 9-ranked **Taylor Fritz**, now 28, brings the power but not the athleticism, and the 2024 US Open finalist is battling knee tendinitis that further decreases his chances.

Ranked a misleading No. 8, **Ben Shelton** had a mediocre 13-7 match record at the Majors and ATP Finals last year and notched only two top-10 wins (over Fritz and Alex de Minaur). The exuberant Shelton, a big-serving left-hander, lacks the solid and consistent groundstrokes to threaten Sincaraz and lost all four matches to No. 3 Alexander Zverev in straight sets on all three surfaces.

- Former world No. 4 **Jack Draper** will miss the Australian Open due to an arm injury. The ruggedly built 24-year-old British left-hander, when healthy, can overpower almost everyone. He proved that when he won Indian Wells last year, whipping Fonseca, Fritz, Shelton, and Holger Rune in straight sets and Alcaraz in three sets. Jack the Ripper will bounce back fast because he possesses

burning ambition, sound technique, and the ability to excel on every surface.

- When three-time titlist **Arthur Fils** returns from the back stress fracture that sidelined him for most of 2025 and for at least January this year, the 21-year-old Frenchman's combination of power and athleticism will reignite his surge into the top 10 and perhaps even the top five.

- Another young Frenchman, **Giovanni Mpetshi Perricard (left)**, will score major upsets throughout the season. At 6 ft 8 in and 225 pounds, Mpetshi Perricard looks like an NBA forward and blasts serves over 150 mph with the ferocity of a LeBron dunk. GMP rarely breaks serve — an abysmal 7.7 per cent last year — so the key to his year and career will be his success, or lack thereof, in tie-breaks. No one wants to face this ultra-dangerous, go-for-broke foe.

- Former No. 6 **Hubert Hurkacz**, who underwent arthroscopic right-knee surgery last July, will win a

tournament on grass and hard courts. With an improved forehand and smarter tactics to capitalise on his strong net game, the No. 53 will return to the ATP top 10 and earn the Comeback of the Year award.

- **Aryna Sabalenka's** favourite book is *The Count of Monte Cristo*. One of Alexandre Dumas' main themes in the classic 1846 historical novel is revenge, and after avenging bitter losses, Sabalenka often talks about it. 'I needed this revenge badly,' she said after trouncing Madison Keys 6-0, 6-1 at Indian Wells, avenging her upset loss to Keys in the Australian Open semifinals. This powerful revenge motive will fuel the hyper-emotional Queen of Hard Courts to her fifth Grand Slam crown.

- **Coco Gauff** recently said her three favourite tennis players to watch are Sinner, Alcaraz, and Daniil Medvedev. She can learn from Sinner's relentless power, Alcaraz's improvisation, and Medvedev's counterpunching. Gauff's 2026 will resemble her 2025 season. She'll